

Q How can we build up an effective support network?

Having a baby with a life-limiting or special-needs condition can be overwhelming for a parent. It's important that throughout your baby's diagnosis and treatment, you accept all offers of help and support available to you.

Taking care of your special-needs baby presents new challenges, and the early years are likely to be a steep learning curve. Not only are you adjusting to being a new parent,

with the lifestyle changes this comes with, but you are also finding out about and dealing with the additional special needs of your baby. The right help and support can be crucial.

HELP AND SUPPORT

Accessing all the help and support that is available to you and your baby can provide you with essential practical and emotional backup, making it easier to deal with your baby's particular needs and enabling you to provide the best possible care for her.



» **Communicate with your partner** Although at times you may respond to challenges differently, no one knows what's going on as intimately as your partner. Don't judge each other and listen to each other's point of view. Set aside some time for just the two of you, and know when to give each other space.



» **Call on your family frequently**—they have a vested interest in you and your baby, and making sure a grandparent, aunt, or uncle is fully involved in the details of your baby's special upbringing will give you a babysitter you can completely trust, so that you can have a break when you need it.



» **Having friends to talk to** can provide welcome relief and a sense of normality. If a friend offers to grab some groceries, bring a meal over, or pick up your dry cleaning, take up the offer willingly and gratefully.



» **Support groups** can provide a new perspective from someone with experience of the situation you're in and provide solutions to challenges that seem hard to fathom when you're trying to cope. Even if there are no solutions, talking to someone who has been through similar events and knowing you're not alone is often enough to keep you positive.



» **Counselors are trained in helping you** to explore and rationalize your emotions. Taking care of a sick or special-needs baby comes with a whole range of emotions, and talking to a counselor can help you channel these for positive effect. Talk to your pediatrician about finding a counselor or therapist with an approach that will suit you.



» **Your pediatrician is there to support you** and your baby. He or she can give advice, a referral to a specialist if you feel you need one, and will also know about organizations in your area that offer respite care to give you a break every now and then. He or she can also advise on your entitlement to Social Security disability income or Medicaid.



» **Try to have someone with you** who can act as an extra pair of ears when you go to doctor appointments and meetings with therapists. This might be your partner, or a close family member or friend. Taking notes will help too, giving you something to refer to that will help you formulate questions for next time, or even for a follow-up call.

Q What causes Down syndrome?

Down syndrome, also known as Trisomy 21, is a chromosomal abnormality. Healthy babies are born with 23 pairs of chromosomes, with one chromosome in each pair received from each parent. Down syndrome occurs when a baby has an extra version of chromosome 21 thereby creating a group of three chromosomes. In the US, Down syndrome occurs in just about one in 700 births, and the chances of having a baby with Down syndrome rise with increasing maternal age (see p.97).

Q What are the signs of Down syndrome?

A person with Down syndrome has distinctive facial and anatomical characteristics, and will have some degree of learning difficulties. Some babies may be born with heart problems and a closed section in the small bowel (known as a duodenal atresia), as well as problems with hearing and vision. Characteristics include:

- » Rounded face with a broad brow.
- » Folds at the inner corners of the upper eyelids.
- » Slanted appearance in the openings for the eyes.
- » Low-set ears.
- » Weakened muscles in the legs and arms.
- » Flattened bridge of the nose, set low down compared with the position of the eyes.
- » Single crease across the palms of the hands.
- » Short little finger that may curve inward.
- » Protruding tongue and overly arched palate.
- » Gap between the big toe and the toe next to it.
- » Short neck with loose skin.



Recognizing Down syndrome Each baby with Down syndrome has an individual appearance, but there are a number of physical characteristics that are common to the condition. They are not always immediately evident at birth.